

open and work on different files, side by side.

To exit from a split window, use the `Ctrl+w+q` shortcut, or at the command line, use `:q!`

While we're on the subject of split windows, there is a command called `vimdiff` for viewing the difference between two files. Suppose you have two versions of a text file, and you want to look at the changes made and compare it with the original, use the command:

```
$ vimdiff file1 file2
```

When you scroll through the file, both file instances will be scrolled. Sounds interesting, right? Take a look at Figure 5.

Vim also supports window tabs. To open a new tab, at the command line, use `:tabnew`. Now to switch between tabs, use the `Ctrl+PAGEUP` or `Ctrl+PAGEUP` shortcuts.

Line numbers

In certain cases, especially while writing code or editing a script, it is convenient to see line numbers for the text file. To enable line numbers, use the command `:set number`. To disable the function, use `:set nonumber`.

Execute external commands

While working from Vim itself, you can execute external commands. To execute and view the output of a command, at the command line, use `:!command`, where 'command' is the command you want to execute. For example, to execute `ls`, try `!ls`

It is also possible to paste the output of the executed command to the currently working file by using `x :!command`. For example, `x !ls`

Vim has awesome features to process the contents of the file using external commands and to paste the output back to the file. It is also able to process text between a range of lines.

There are situations when a part of the text needs to be processed. Vim makes it convenient to process a given range of lines using external commands.

`tr` is a utility to perform translations based on the sequence inputs. We can easily perform translations such as lower case to upper case conversion using `tr` as the following bash command line.

```
slynux@slynux-laptop:~$ echo "This is a line of text 1234" | tr 'a-z' 'A-Z'
THIS IS A LINE OF TEXT 123
```

Suppose we have a large text file and the text between the lines 3-5 is to be converted to upper case. We can perform it easily using the external commands methodology like `:3,5 tr 'a-z' 'A-Z'`,

which instructs Vim to perform `tr 'a-z' 'A-Z'` for the text between the lines 3-5.

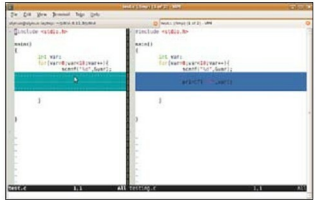


Figure 5: Files opened using the `vimdiff` command

In this way, any kind of external command can be coupled with Vim to process any part of the text in a file, in a handy way.

Moving the cursor in a file

Vim enables moving the cursor to different positions by accepting different references. For programming tasks, often compile/runtime errors occur and compiler return errors are noticed with line numbers. In such cases, we need to move the cursor immediately to the error line referenced by the line number. To move to a line referenced by a line number, use `:line_number`. For example, to move to line 50 use `:50`

Essentially, we can also perform some actions using the corresponding commands:

- Move cursor to beginning of line – `0`
- Move cursor to end of line – `$`
- Move cursor to beginning of next line – `+`
- Move cursor to end of file – `G`

Scrolling page by page is very useful while dealing with large files. To do so, use `Ctrl+f` for forward scroll and `Ctrl+b` for backward scroll.

Getting help

Vim has an embedded command line called `:help` to get help with different operations. For more information on making substitutions, use `:help substitutions`; for search, use `:help search` and so on. To quit from help mode, use `q`

If you would like more insights into the Vim editor, I would like to recommend *A byte of Vim* written by Swaroop C H [www.swaroopch.com/notes/Vim]. I guess that's all for now. Hope you will join our Vim club soon. Happy hacking, till we meet again! 

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